

while simultaneously having a virtual “avatar” that provided a glimpse into what futuristic virtual human interfaces could look like.

Chat and Chatbots

The advent of the Internet brought with it the instant messaging revolution. Chatting with friends online became a global phenomenon, so it was only natural that chat bots were developed to take advantage of this.

The first and most popular chatterbot to come out was on the AOL instant messaging service. It was called the SmarterChild and garnered over 30 million friends over its “lifetime”. As with any modern service around the Internet, SmarterChild originated as an advertising gimmick. Here was a tool that marketing firms could use to talk to people, get them hooked and then slowly push a product or a service.

SmarterChild was perhaps the first chat bot to be connected to the web in such a way that it became a sort of virtual assistant. While chatting, users could ask SmarterChild the score in a match or the weather outside and SmarterChild would appropriately trawl through web sites of leading sports channels or weather bureaus to come up with the information. This amount of artificial intelligence proposed the dawn of a new era.

A.L.I.C.E

In modern chat bots, perhaps none is as admired as A.L.I.C.E, or Artificial Linguistic Internet Computer Entity. Based on the same principles as ELIZA, this artificial conversational agent has won the coveted Loebner Prize three times. Whether it can be called an intelligent agent, though, has a lot to do with who you talk to.

If we go by the Turing Test, then A.L.I.C.E. would definitely be an artificial intelligence system since it has been thrice considered to be the most human-like chatterbot. But if you speak to its inventor Dr. Richard Wallace, his entire line of thinking about conversational agents kind of makes the Turing Test moot.

Wallace believes that human conversation – or at least, the online chat aspect of human conversation – boils down to a key set of phrases and sentences. It’s based on an old language theory called Zipf’s law, which states that a small number of words make up most of what we want to say. Wallace estimates (in an interview in the New York Times) that by teaching A.L.I.C.E. around 40,000 responses, it would be able to carry out a normal conversation with most people.